INNOVATEX x Ascend UNIVERSITY

Ascend x waypoint

AN ASCEND CAREERS PLATFORM

A Continuous Model for Student Resilience

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Land Acknowledgement

InnovateX respectfully acknowledges that Ascend University is located on the traditional territories of the peoples of Treaty 7 in Southern Alberta. This includes the Blackfoot Confederacy—Siksika, Kainai, and Piikani as well as the Stoney Nakoda Nations of Bearspaw, Chiniki, and Wesley, the Tsuut’ina Nation, and the Métis Nation of Alberta, Region 3. The InnovateX team is grateful for the opportunity to gather and collaborate on this land today.

Executive Summary

Today's undergraduates are facing three main issues that are degrading the traditional promise of higher education

Three Pillar Problem

Operational Overwhelm	Existential Uncertainty	AI-Driven Disruption
• Academic pressure & workload • Indecisive learning paths • Résumé-driven overcommitment	• Isolated direction & loss of meaning • Lower satisfaction in high achievement • Constant search of purpose and identity crisis	• Reshaping entry-level work • Devaluing traditional credentials • Increasing career uncertainty as new trends arise

Overarching Idea

Undergraduates face growing anxiety and misalignment as AI reshapes the future of work, while current university career support systems fail to build the self-awareness, human skills, and adaptability needed for long-term career resilience.

InnovateX Hybrid Solution

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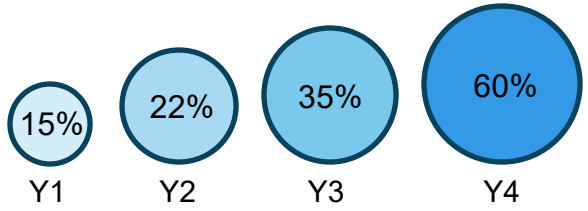
Ascend UNIVERSITY **Career Hub Redesign**

Target Market Insights

% of Students Using Career Services by Year of Study



Insight: Career support is largely reactive and driven by urgency instead of continuous development

Uncertainty and anxiety drive avoidance

73% **of university students** report feeling *uncertain or very uncertain* about their career direction

58% say career uncertainty is a *significant source of stress*

5-7 Students now change careers **5–7 times** on average over a lifetime

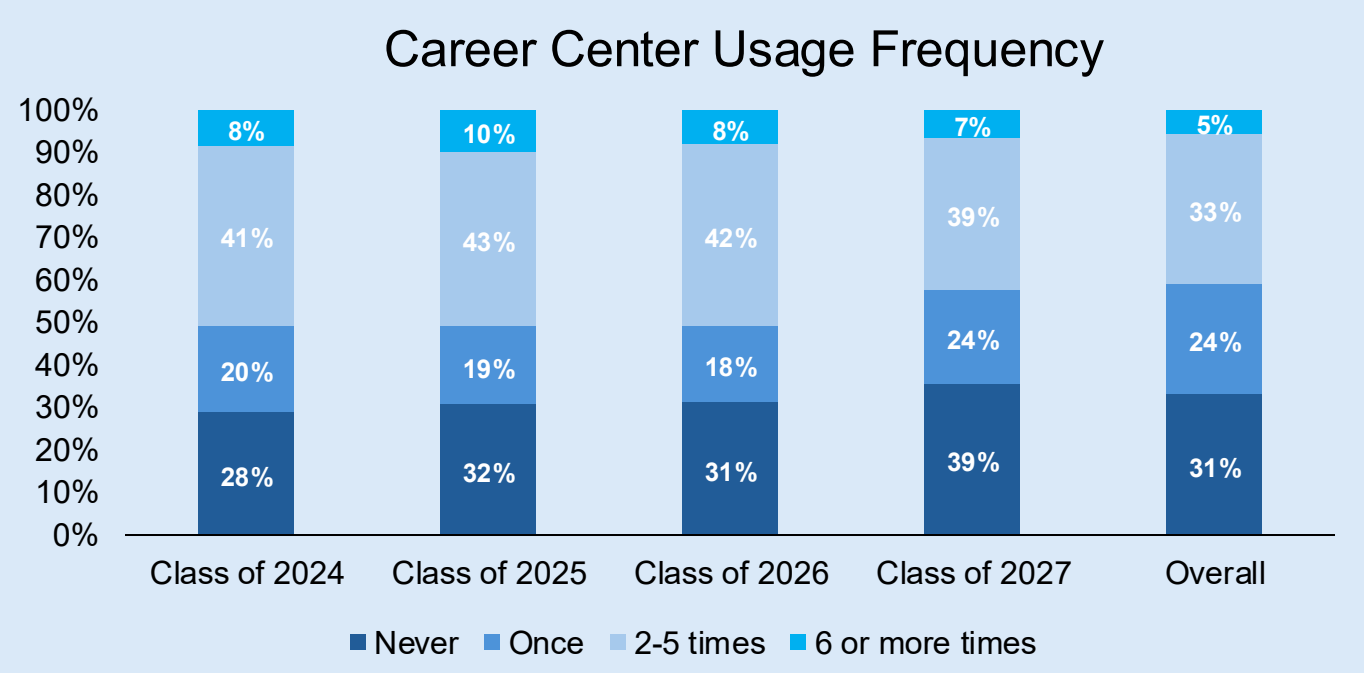
Insight: Career systems optimized for one-time decisions (résumés, placements) do not match reality anymore.

How do students engage?

75% higher retention from experiential learning compared to passive instruction

70% drop-off from digital career platforms within the first month

Insight: Career support must be interactive, applied, and anchored in real experiences to sustain engagement.



Sources: Insider ED, National Association of Colleges and Employers,

User Persona

User

Aiyana Yerxa

Traits

Age: 18
Year: 1st-year undergraduate
Program: English language/ Social Sciences (undecided) concentration)
Profile: High-achieving, involved, anxious about the future

> "I'm busy all the time, but I don't feel like I'm moving toward anything."

> "Everyone says to be future-ready, but no one explains what that actually means anymore."

> "I don't need another résumé workshop. I need to know if I'm even building the right skills."

Pain Points

1. **High Effort, Low Direction** (constantly busy but lacks a clear sense of "why")
2. **Uncertainty About Future Relevance** (worried that her skills today will not matter by the time she graduates)
3. **Transactional, Fragmented Support** (university services help with tasks (résumés, applications, etc.) but fail to support deeper needs like resilience, adaptability, and long-term growth) especially as an Indigenous student.

Empowerment Platform Demo

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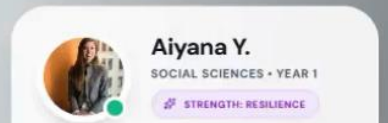
Student Hub

Where do you want to go today?



Aiyana Y.

SOCIAL SCIENCES • YEAR 1

STRENGTH: RESILIENCE

TO DO LIST — 2 Items

- [ ] **Submit Reflection** — Due Today, 5:00 PM
- [ ] **Sign up for Labs** — Opens Tomorrow

SKILL PROGRESS

Communication — Level 3

320 / 500 XP

SHORTCUTS

Library · Help · Jobs · Wellness

NEW JOBS

MARKET DATA

Job Trends

Enter →

ACTIVE

BUILD SKILLS

Workshops

Enter →

LOG NOW

REFLECT

Journal

Enter →

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Career Hub Redesign

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Compass Room

Dialogue Room

Practice Room

Commons Room

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Compass Room

A reflection/identity-fueling zone

What happens here:
- Guided journaling sessions (identity, values, timelines)
- Psychological check-ins (not therapy, but reflective coaching)
- Life-mapping exercises (past → present → future)

Design features
- Warm lighting, plants, soft textures
- No screens (or very limited)
- Journaling prompts physically embedded in walls
- Timers or bells to mark “reflection sessions”

Human skills trained
- Self-reflection
- Emotional literacy
- Internal motivation

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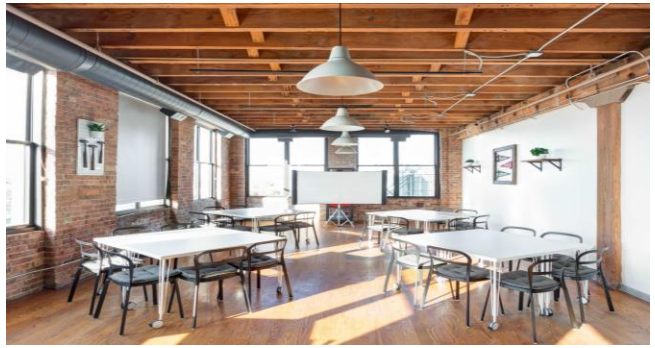
Dialogue Room

Conversation and Coaching Zone



What happens here
- 1:1 career + life coaching
- Peer mentoring circles
- “How are you actually doing?” check-ins
- Decision-making conversations

Design features
- Circular seating (removes hierarchy)
- Semi-private but not clinical
- Visible conversation norms on walls

Human skills trained
- Emotional awareness
- Active listening
- Vulnerability and verbal communication
- Asking for help

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Compass Room

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Practice Room

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waypoint Room

Practice Room

Human Skills Training Zone

What happens here

- Communication & storytelling workshops
- Conflict resolution role-play
- AI-era skills labs (judgment, ethics, collaboration)
- Leadership simulations

Design features

- Flexible furniture (moveable, reconfigurable)
- Whiteboard walls
- Recording setup (optional, for reflection—not grading)
- Workshop schedules always visible

Human skills trained

- Confidence
- Ethical reasoning
- Collaboration and communication

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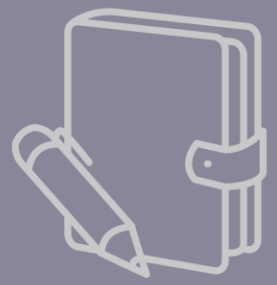

Compass Room

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Commons Room

Community and Belonging Zone

What happens here

- Industry professionals in casual conversation
- Student-led discussions
- “Career story nights”
- Interdisciplinary meetups (not majors-based)

Design features

- Café-style seating
- No formal stage—everything feels accessible
- Events that don’t feel like “networking”
- Light snacks provided

Human skills trained

- Relationship building
- Informal communication
- Cross-disciplinary learning

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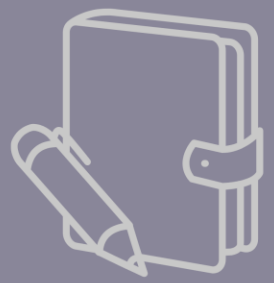

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Room

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Integration Zone

What happens here

- Students log reflections from Ascend sessions into waypoint
- Guided goal-setting and pathway-mapping sessions using the platform
- Visual timelines that sync physical milestones with digital progress
- Light-touch check-ins where staff help students interpret their data

Design features

- Shared screens and personal tablets dedicated to waypoint use
- Physical-to-digital bridges (QR codes, prompts, transition stations)

Human skills trained

- Decision-making under uncertainty
- Long-term thinking
- Self-direction and agency
- Ownership of one’s evolving path

User Journey: Anxiety into Agency, Uncertainty into Upskilling

Progression through a typical graduation path model

Year 1

Low ← → High

Confidence Level

"I'm extremely overwhelmed with feelings of isolation, creating connections and choosing the right path"

Current Steps: Waypoint platform and career center introduction

Key Takeaway:

Student enters with high anxiety and little sense of direction

Year 2

Low ← → High

Confidence Level

"I feel less anxious and a bit more confident but am nervous about what skills I should focus on at the moment"

Current Steps: Utilize Waypoint upskilling and core resources

Key Takeaway:

Student has started to actively utilize and benefit from learning modules

Year 3

Low ← → High

Confidence Level

"I have learned some core skills but I am curious as to what my industry is demanding"

Current Steps: Focus on future-proofing skills and emerging tech practice

Key Takeaway:

Student is focusing on industry-demanded skills to further future-proof their skillset

Year 4

Low ← → High

Confidence Level

"I feel prepared and eager to enter the workforce. I just need to polish my professional traits."

Current Steps: Polish job-required materials and career necessities

Key Takeaway:

Student has up-to-date human-centric and tech skills and is preparing to enter the workforce

Implementation Timeline

	MONTH 1- 4	MONTH 5	MONTH 6	MONTH 7-12
	TRANSFORM	PILOT	LAUNCH	SCALE
Key Milestones	Hub Opens Platform Deployed	Official Launch – all 1st yr students enrolled		1st Data Review YR 1 Assessment
Activities	✓ Renovate space layout/design ✓ Hire core team ✓ Upgrade tech infrastructure & install platform access points ✓ Develop platform beta	✓ Launch with 50-100 students ✓ Test hub + platform integration ✓ Host first event with 5-10 employers & student orgs ✓ Collect feedback data	✓ Launch marketing campaigns ✓ Open hub + platform to all students campus-wide ✓ Full programming schedule ✓ Onboard 50 corporate partners	✓ Analyze engagement data ✓ Refine content & features ✓ Scale successful programs ✓ Expand partnerships
Responsible leads & participants	• Facilities Manager • Hub Director • Software Development Team	• Career Services Team • Marketing Director • 2 Academic Deans	• All Academic Deans • Alumni Office • Ambassadors • Social Media Team	• Data Analysts • Advisory Board

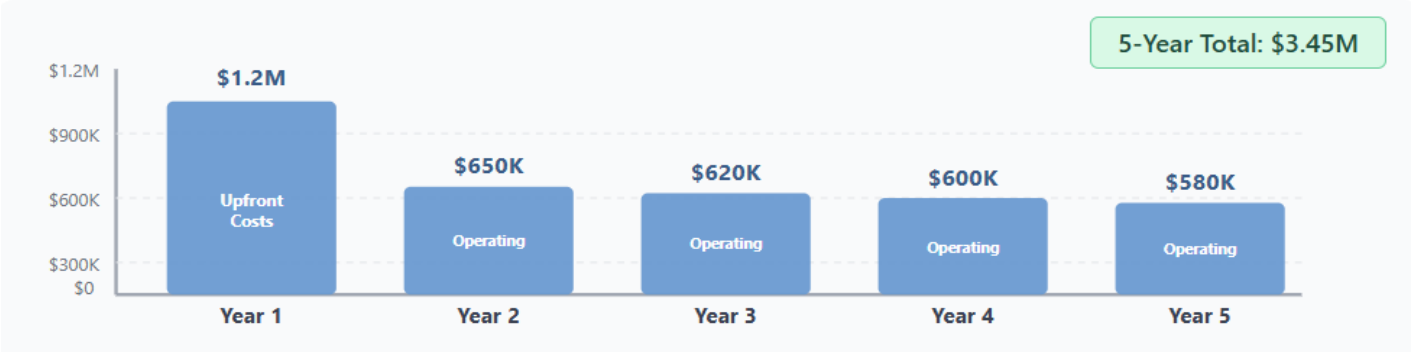
Human-Centric & Future-proofing KPI Tracking

Foundation / Early Stage | Development / Exploration | Application | Transition / Exit Outcome

	Assessment parameter	Unit	Measurable KPI	Channel	Target
Clarity & Purpose	Articulation of strengths	%	% of students who can articulate and identify their strengths	Structured reflection or assessment rubric	**+25–40%** within first academic year
	Sense of Direction	%	% of students reporting “clear sense of direction”	Pre/post survey	**+30%** by end of Year 2
	Growth Plans	# of plans	Completion rate of personalized growth plans	Growth plan outline via Waypoint	**70%**+ of participating students each year
Resilience & Psychological Readiness	Resilience	# of points	Change in resilience score	Pre/post assessment	**+15–20%** improvement YOY
	Anxiety (career-related)	%	Reduction in career-related anxiety	Self-reported (Likert scale)	**−20%** by program midpoint
	Adaptability	# of points	Student confidence in navigating uncertainty	Standardized Pre/Post Confidence Index	**+20%** by Year 3
Future-Ready Skills & Engagement	Responsible AI Usage	%	% of students meeting “Responsible AI Use” competency	3-part competency standard: Intentional, Human, Ethical	**60–70%** of students by Year 3
	AI Literacy (Industry-specific)	# of points	AI literacy & industry-skill competency gains	Pre/post skill diagnostics	**25%** average improvement YOY
	Platform Engagement	# of hours	Hours per week of Waypoint activity	Waypoint platform analytics	**2** hours per week
Institutional	Student Confidence ★	%	Graduate confidence at exit	Graduation year pre/post survey	**+30%** agreement of confidence at graduation

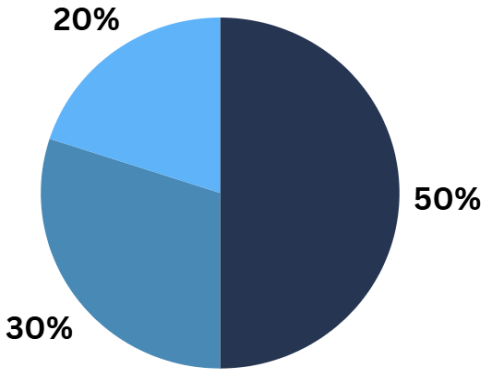
Financial Projections

ANNUAL COSTS (5-YR PROJECTION)



Year 1: One-time setup ($540K) + operations ($660K) = $1.2M
Years 2-5: Recurring costs only: salaries, hosting, maintenance, events, supplies
Total 5-YR Costs One-time investment pays off with sustainable operations.

FUNDING SOURCES

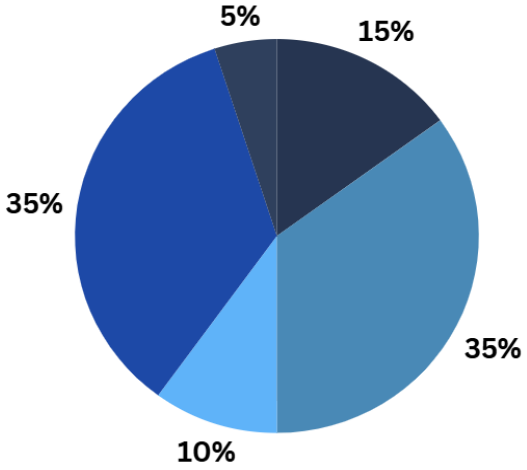


University Budget
Reallocate mid-size career services budget $400k

Corporate Partners
Tiered pricing (Platinum, Gold, SIlver). Industry benchmark $10K-100K per partner

Grants
Federal Dept of Ed NSF, AI Assess Fund, CIFAR

YEAR 1 - COST BREAKDOWN



Hub Renovation (15%): ~1,000 sq ft @ $120/sq ft. *RS Means data.*

Platform Development (35%): Custom platform build ($200K), UX/UI design ($40K), Integrations ($25K), Testing ($15K). *Clutch.co dev rates.*

Equipment &Tech (10%): Furniture, computers, AV. *Vendor quotes.*

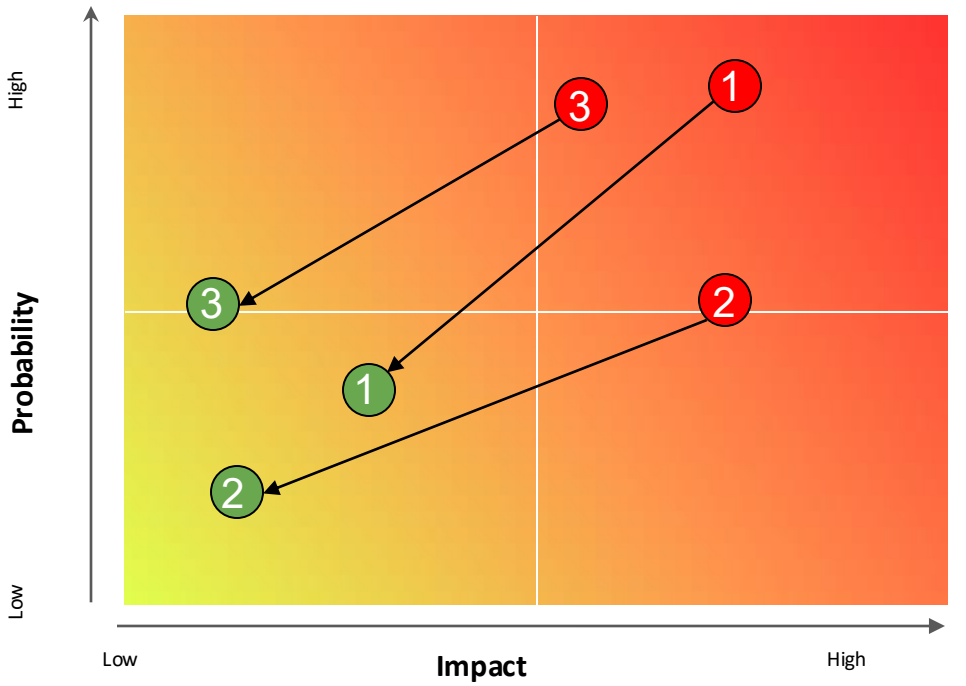
Staffing (35%): Hub Director ($70K), 2 Career Coaches ($100K total), Developers ($60K), 5 Student Workers ($10K). *Glassdoor*

Operations & Marketing (5%): Marketing, supplies, utilities. *Event estimates*

Risks and Mitigations

Criteria Considered for Risks	Student Engagement	Tool Fatigue	Equity

Risk Matrix



	Risks	Mitigation
1	Low sustained student engagement over time	Integrate waypoint onboarding into Ascend workshops and coaching
2	Digital platform feels like “just another career app”	waypoint is a continuation of real experiences from Ascend, not a standalone product
3	Equity gaps persist if access depends on confidence, time, or insider knowledge	Multiple access points (digital/ physical), specialized advisors, partner with student engagement offices

Appendix

1

https://ascend-os-ingestion-engine-994858256186.us-west1.run.app/

http://localhost:3000/

https://github.com/makac1896/ascend-career-reskilling/

https://ascend-career-reskilling.vercel.app/